

Primary Source Reading 1: Internal Conflict and the Three Parts of the Soul

Optima Academy Online / Philosophy & Ethics / High School Honors (9–12) From Plato's Republic, Book IV, translated by Benjamin Jowett Read before Lesson 11a: The Three Parts of the Soul

Before you read: Socrates wants to know whether the soul is one simple thing or has distinct parts. He starts from a principle of logic — the same thing cannot act in opposite ways toward the same object at the same time — and then asks whether we ever actually experience something like that inside ourselves. As you read, follow the example of thirst carefully, and watch for the moment a third force enters the argument.

A Principle of Logic

SOCRATES: The same thing clearly cannot act or be acted upon in the same part or in relation to the same thing at the same time, in contrary ways; and therefore whenever this contradiction occurs in things apparently the same, we know that they are really not the same, but different. (436b)

Thirsty, and Yet Unwilling to Drink

SOCRATES: Thirst is one of these essentially relative terms... thirst pure and simple will desire drink pure and simple, which is the natural satisfaction of thirst, as food is of hunger... Then the soul of the thirsty one, in so far as he is thirsty, desires only drink; for this he yearns and tries to obtain it?

GLAUCON: That is plain.

SOCRATES: And if you suppose something which pulls a thirsty soul away from drink, that must be different from the thirsty principle which draws him like a beast to drink; for, as we were saying, the same thing cannot at the same time with the same part of itself act in contrary ways about the same. No more than you can say that the hands of the archer push and pull the bow at the same time, but what you say is that one hand pushes and the other pulls.

GLAUCON: Exactly so.

SOCRATES: And might a man be thirsty, and yet unwilling to drink?

GLAUCON: Yes, it constantly happens.

SOCRATES: And in such a case what is one to say? Would you not say that there was something in the soul bidding a man to drink, and something else forbidding him, which is other and stronger than the principle which bids him?

GLAUCON: I should say so.

SOCRATES: And the forbidding principle is derived from reason, and that which bids and attracts proceeds from passion and disease?

GLAUCON: Clearly.

SOCRATES: Then we may fairly assume that they are two, and that they differ from one another; the one with which a man reasons, we may call the rational principle of the soul, the other, with which he loves and hungers and thirsts and feels the flutterings of any other desire, may be termed the irrational or appetitive, the ally of sundry pleasures and satisfactions. (439a–d)

The Story of Leontius

SOCRATES: There is a story which I remember to have heard, and in which I put faith. The story is, that Leontius, the son of Aglaion, coming up one day from the Piraeus, under the north wall on the outside, observed some dead bodies lying on the ground at the place of execution. He felt a desire to see them, and also a dread and abhorrence of them; for a time he struggled and covered his eyes, but at length the desire got the better of him; and forcing them open, he ran up to the dead bodies, saying, Look, ye wretches, take your fill of the fair sight.

GLAUCON: I have heard the story myself.

SOCRATES: The moral of the tale is, that anger at times goes to war with desire, as though they were two distinct things. (439e–440a)

SOCRATES: Are there not many other cases in which we observe that when a man's desires violently prevail over his reason, he reviles himself, and is angry at the violence within him, and that in this struggle, which is like the struggle of factions in a State, his spirit is on the side of his reason? (440a–b)

After you read: Notice the shape of the argument: first Socrates establishes that reason and appetite must be different things, using the case of a thirsty man who refuses to drink. Then, with Leontius, a third force appears — not reason, and not appetite, but an angry, self-directed indignation that sides with reason against desire. That third force is what the lesson will name *thumos*, the spirited part. By the end of this reading, all three parts are on the table, though only two have been named outright.